

Iran's Leader Vows Revenge as Oil Shock Grips the Globe



One of two tankers that were burning near Iraq on Thursday. Strikes were also reported in Kuwait, Bahrain and Dubai, and the price of oil rose to about \$100 a barrel.

Strait Barrier and Attacks in Gulf Add to Peril

This article is by **Yeganeh Torbati, Sanam Mahoozi and Thomas Fuller.**

Iran's new supreme leader struck a defiant tone on Thursday in his first public comments since succeeding his dead father, vowing to continue blocking the Strait of Hormuz, a choke point for the world's oil supply, on a day when multiple vessels came under attack in the Persian Gulf.

The attacks on shipping sent panic through oil markets as they digested what the International Energy Agency called "the largest supply disruption in the history of the global oil market." The price of oil rose sharply on Thursday, hovering around \$100 a barrel, despite a plan by the agency, a coalition of 32 nations, to release 400 million barrels of oil from strategic reserves, including 172 million by the United States.

Images and reports from across the Gulf pointed to widespread attacks. Two oil tankers were burning off the coast of Iraq early Thursday. Saudi Arabia said it had destroyed two drones that were heading toward the kingdom's huge Shaybah oil field. Kuwaiti authorities said Kuwait Airport was damaged in several drone strikes.

In Oman, an important oil export terminal, the Mina al Fahal port near the capital, Muscat, closed early Thursday for security reasons, the port's operator said. Images from Bahrain showed a gray miasma drifting across the landscape after fuel tanks were struck, sending the toxic cloud of smoke into the air. And in Dubai, pictures circulated of a gaping hole in the modern, glassy facade of a skyscraper after what authorities said was an Iranian drone strike.

In a statement read on Iranian state television, the new supreme leader, Mojtaba Khamenei, mourned the Iranians dead in the conflict and vowed to avenge "the blood of martyrs." He especially dwelled on the schoolchildren killed in a strike that an ongoing Pentagon investigation has determined was probably a mistaken attack by the U.S. military.

And he warned that Iran was studying the "opening of other fronts where the enemy has little experience."

"Dear brother combatants!" Mr. Khamenei added. "The will of the masses is for continued effective and punishing defense."

In a news conference later on Thursday, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu of Israel was

Lebanon's Hezbollah Loyalists, Weary of War, Begin to Waver

By CHRISTINA GOLDBAUM

BEIRUT, Lebanon — The Lebanese are exhausted.

They are tired of frantically evacuating their homes and living in makeshift shelters for months on end. Tired of the thunderous booms of explosions echoing across the capital day and night. Tired of homes in the south being bombed and towns flattened. Tired of Hezbollah dragging Lebanon into wars on behalf of others — and of a government too weak to stop it.

"Our people are tired," said Leila Safa, 65, who had fled her home in southern Lebanon twice in the past year and a half because of wars between Hezbollah and Israel.

"We just want to live peacefully," said Hassan Kuaik, a 64-year-old farmer whose home near Lebanon's border with Israel was badly damaged in the previous escalation between the two sides. Now he fears it will be destroyed.

"Tired? We're beyond tired," said Hind, 43, sitting on Beirut's seaside corniche, where she had slept the night before after evacuating her home in the southern suburbs, where Hezbollah, an Iranian-backed militant group, holds sway. She declined to give her full name for security reasons.

Even in Lebanon, where new crises tend to erupt before the country recovers from the last one, the latest outbreak of war caught people off guard. Few in the country — government officials, foreign diplomats, even Hezbollah's supporters — expected that the group would fire on Israel in support of Iran after being battered by its escalation of hostilities with Israel in 2024.

Now, Lebanon is engulfed in its second major war in less than two years, and the loyalty of Hezbollah's base is being tested as never before. Once fervent ideological zeal for resisting Israel at any cost has given way to the brutal reality of what Hezbollah has brought on Lebanon in recent years: two wars with Israel, each fought on behalf of others, but with the costs felt at home.

The first war began after Hezbollah launched rockets at Israeli positions in October 2023 in solidarity with Hamas, the Iranian-backed militant group that had just led an attack on southern Israel, killing about 1,200 people. That prompted Israel to launch a blistering yearlong assault that left much of Lebanon and Hezbollah battered.



Smoke rose over the southern suburbs of Beirut, Lebanon, on Wednesday after Israeli airstrikes.

Since Israel and Hezbollah reached a cease-fire in 2024, the militant group has largely remained on the sidelines. It did not respond militarily as Israel launched near-daily strikes in Lebanon in response to what Israeli officials said were Hezbollah battered.

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A Social Media Addiction Trial Is Eclipsed by Society's Verdict

By DAVID STREITFELD

LOS ANGELES — Social media has been on trial in Los Angeles Superior Court, although you might not know it.

There were no crowds outside the court on a recent day, clamoring for the attention of reporters, because there were hardly any reporters. In the courtroom, the space reserved for the media was half-filled. The space for the public had lots of room, too.

The case, brought by a 20-year-old woman against Meta's Instagram and Google's YouTube for optimizing their products to her mental and physical detriment, isn't much on social media either.

Posts about it on Facebook rarely have more than a handful of comments. On Reddit, the first post about the trial is headlined, "Why is no one talking about the social media trial?" There were just a few responses.

The O.J. Simpson trial, it is not. This might seem surprising for a case that is in many ways about so many of us and our increasingly online behavior. But society long ago rendered a verdict on social media, which has been under such heavy criticism for nearly a decade that the talk about its harms has become close to background noise.

Three billion people use Facebook at least once a month. Three billion use Instagram. Both are controlled by one company (Meta) and one man (Mark Zuckerberg). Throw in YouTube and TikTok and a few other platforms, and you have a technology that has become inextricably entwined with human life in less than a generation.

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In Cartel-Stricken Corner, Mexicans Are Open to U.S. Intervention



Mexico sent 12,000 soldiers to the state of Sinaloa to fight the cartels, but residents still live in fear.

By PAULINA VILLEGAS and JACK NICAS

CULIACÁN, Mexico — On the whole, Mexicans do not support President Trump's proposal of U.S. military strikes against their country's powerful cartels. Nearly eight in 10 Mexicans said they opposed the idea in a national poll last month.

But in one battered corner of northwestern Mexico, where the cartels have long operated, that resistance is beginning to crack.

In Sinaloa, a state of three million people that has been the stronghold of the Sinaloa Cartel for decades, residents are about 20 months into a war that began when the cartel fractured into two.

Mexican security forces now patrol the streets. Businesses have shuttered. Families have fled.

Many residents here said they were desperate for peace, at what

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China's New 'Ethnic Unity' Law

A raft of provisions approved by Beijing's rubber-stamp legislature will affect education, housing policy, entertainment and other areas. **PAGE A5**

A No-Booze Dublin Pub Crawl

A wander through some famed watering holes in Ireland's capital reveals a booming alcohol-free scene and a cultural shift. **PAGE A4**

Glee for Chilean Conservatives

The presidential inauguration of José Antonio Kast is the latest milestone in a broader shift toward pro-Trump alignment in Latin America. **PAGE A10**

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A Long Search for His Mom

Antonio Wiley was 14 when his mother vanished. It took decades and a detective's persistence to find her. **PAGE A20**

Attack at Michigan Synagogue

A driver was killed after he exchanged gunfire with security guards at Temple Israel outside Detroit. **PAGE A19**



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In Sled Hockey, He Does It All

Declan Farmer, an offensive and defensive force for the U.S., is also a voice for Paralympians off the ice. **PAGE B8**

Another Round of Rebukes

Eileen Gu, the U.S.-born Olympic freestyle skier who competes for China, was celebrated in San Francisco. **PAGE B10**

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Selma March Organizer

Bernard Lafayette Jr., an associate of Martin Luther King Jr. and John Lewis, was involved in key moments of the civil rights movement. He was 85. **PAGE A24**

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Will the Money Come Back?

Companies and individual consumers expect refunds on tariffs the Supreme Court has deemed unlawful. **PAGE B1**

Pritzker Laureate Named

Smiljan Radic earned architecture's top prize after delays stemming from a Tom Pritzker-Jeffrey Epstein link. **PAGE B7**



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And the Oscars Will Go To ...

Kyle Buchanan's crystal ball is cloudier than usual, but he is still predicting this year's Academy Award winners. **PAGE C7**

Seeing Goodness All Around

Daniel Radcliffe's fondness for the audience radiates outward in the play "Every Brilliant Thing." **PAGE C1**

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Sloane Crosley

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